

OPTION 2:

A Proposed Women's Empowerment and Livelihood Hub: Creating Spaces for Economic Independence and Community Support

Thesis Statement:

A Women's Empowerment and Livelihood Hub can promote inclusive community development by providing women with accessible spaces that support economic growth, personal development, and social well-being.

Another field that I am interested in exploring is community-based architecture focused on women's development. My proposed title for this topic is *A Women's Empowerment and Livelihood Hub: Creating Spaces for Economic Independence and Community Support*. I chose this topic because it is closely connected to my personal experiences growing up with a single mother.

I was still young when my mother became a single parent, and throughout the years I witnessed the sacrifices she made to provide for our family. I also saw how difficult it can be for women to access opportunities, support systems, and resources despite carrying significant responsibilities. Beyond my own family, I know many women including relatives, and the mothers of my friends who chose to work abroad as overseas Filipino workers to support their children and families. Their sacrifices often go unnoticed, yet they continue to work hard for the people they love.

Because of these experiences, I became interested in the idea of creating a space that is specifically designed to support women's growth and development. If women play such an important role in families and communities, why are there still limited facilities dedicated to helping them improve their livelihoods, develop new skills, and access support services?

Rather than functioning as a conventional training center, I envision the proposed hub as a dynamic environment where women can learn, work, collaborate, and access support services within a single facility. The project may explore how architecture can create opportunities by bringing together spaces for livelihood development, entrepreneurship, childcare, wellness, and community engagement.

From a design perspective, the hub could be organized as a collection of interconnected spaces centered around a communal courtyard that encourages interaction, support, and a sense of belonging. The facility may include livelihood training workshops, digital learning laboratories, business incubation spaces, cooperative retail areas where women can sell locally made products, childcare facilities, counseling centers, and multipurpose community halls. Flexible spaces could also accommodate temporary markets, exhibitions, seminars, and community events.

One design concept that interests me is the idea of a "*Village Within a Village*," where the facility functions as a small support ecosystem rather than a single building. Different clusters could represent various stages of empowerment from learning and skills development to business creation and community leadership. Through landscaped courtyards, shaded walkways, and open gathering spaces, the architecture could promote interaction while creating a safe and welcoming environment.

The study may also explore sustainable design strategies that can reduce operational costs and improve user comfort. Possible features include passive cooling systems, natural ventilation, rainwater harvesting, solar energy integration, edible gardens, and urban farming spaces that can be incorporated into livelihood programs. These elements would not only support environmental sustainability but could also serve as educational opportunities for users.

Theoretical considerations for this proposed study include inclusive design, community-centered planning, and feminist urbanism. These concepts may provide a framework for understanding how architecture can respond to the specific needs of women while promoting accessibility, safety, flexibility, and social inclusion. Existing women's centers and community development facilities in the Philippines and abroad may also be examined to identify design strategies that can be adapted to local conditions.

Through this proposal, I hope to explore how architecture can move beyond simply providing shelter and instead become a platform for empowerment. The proposed Women's Empowerment and Livelihood Hub seeks to investigate how thoughtfully designed spaces can support women in building skills, generating income, strengthening social connections, and improving their overall quality of life while creating positive impacts for families and communities.